



Historic landmark: Asian Games silver medallist Tejaswin Shankar became the first Indian to breach the 8,000-point mark in decathlon, amassing 8,057 points in Ranchi.

Dawson, reminded him of this. "Let's go and run 44 seconds," Dawson told him. Vishal would do just that. In a field in which an unprecedented five runners had clocked below 46 seconds in the semifinals, he steadily pulled away from his chasers and then stormed away from the pack in the home straight.

As he whooshed past the finish line, Vishal didn't celebrate right away. He waited for the digital board to confirm what he had hoped for. 44.98 it flashed. That was the cue for him to pull off his running bib, on which he had written with a black felt pen, '44 coming home'. That gesture was for the cameras. To release his own emotions, he screamed, "Yes!" He sought out his father,

Thennarasu, who had travelled from Tamil Nadu as he does for every competition his son runs in India, and wrapped him in a bear hug.

Even as all this was going on, coach Dawson was sprinting across the stadium to the finish line, hooting with joy. When Vishal caught sight of him, he leapt into his arms. "We did it!" yelled Vishal, in between shouts of "Let's go India!" by the Jamaican-born Dawson.

It was an emotional high point, but the day wasn't done just yet. Just a few minutes later, Tejaswin Shankar lined up for the start of the 1500m. The 26-year-old had already held the Indian decathlon national record of 7826 heading into the Federation Cup. He had also scored a wind-assisted total of 7947 points earlier this year. But 8000, he would also admit, carries an aura of its very own. Fewer athletes have an 8000-point decathlon to their name than a sub-45-second 400m.

Scaling Mount 8000

Tejaswin had been asked before the competition why he was risking participating in the decathlon. He was also the national record holder in the high jump and, since the purpose of the Federation Cup was primarily to serve as a qualification event for the Commonwealth Games in July, surely it might have been easier for him to take part in the high jump, for which the qualification standard had been set relatively modestly, compared to the 10 events of the decathlon, in which there were multiple chances of failure.

For Tejaswin, though, the answer was a simple one. He had always competed for the challenge, and the 8000-point decathlon was the ultimate challenge for him.

The event came with rewards but also risks. And that's how Tejaswin had yo-yoed through two days of competition. He started the first day with three Personal Bests in the 100m, long jump and the 400m. His